

VIREN SHARMA, 40
Pups Rescue & Adoption
Jaipur

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

Pet *Project*

***Core work:** He has helped street dog pups find homes and parents, including the governor and police commissioner of Jaipur. Actor John Abraham, who was moved to tears on KBC while talking of the plight of strays, follows him on Instagram*

By **ROHIT PARIHAR**

For a long time, Viren Sharma, 40, was content to run the veterinarian medical shop his grandfather started in 1957. In 2000, he began breeding dogs commercially. Then, three years ago, a desperate call asking him to save street dog puppies became his lifelong mission. Sharma brought four pups home and posted an appeal on social media for locals to adopt them. Within hours, his tiny wards had found new pet parents. Sharma has now gone on to find homes for 2,500-odd indie pups, some of whom he had rescued and others who were brought to him by dog lovers.

Besides facilitating the adoption of indie pups, Sharma also began feeding street dogs every Saturday, tending up to 100 dogs a day, which went up to 1,200 during the Covid lockdown. His staff would prepare the food and he would go around in his Fortuner looking for street dogs to feed. With no official effort to neuter or spay street dogs, their numbers run into several lakhs. Most either fall victim to road mishaps or become easy prey for leopards. Convinced there couldn't be a better man for the job, many of his 60,000 followers on social media—actor John Abraham among them—began asking him to take care of indie pups.

From the time a pup is brought to him till it finds a home, Sharma bears the entire cost of its vaccination, radium collar, feeding, and microchip installation out of his own resources. It costs him approximately Rs 3,750 for every pup. Currently, he has data on 12,000 pups awaiting adoption; he claims he finds a home for 200-odd every month. His home in Mahesh Nagar and his parental home at Paanch Batti act as an orphanage for people to come and drop pups. Since there is no law governing pet adoption, Sharma fulfils some minimum formalities, which include taking an affidavit from the pet parents along with their identity proofs and a picture of the pup. His team does a follow-up every month to see if the dog is doing fine.

Convincing people who come to him for a purebred to adopt an indie instead is tough, Sharma admits. "But I tell them that just as every man cannot look like Hrithik Roshan but can still be a good human being, looks don't matter for dogs either," he says.

Do people abandon indies once they grow up? To his surprise, Sharma says, people have returned purebreds but not indies. Sharma keeps the abandoned dogs so that dog lovers can come for some pup therapy.

Governor Kalraj Mishra accepted his request to adopt a pup at Raj Bhawan as did Anand Srivastava, the Jaipur commissioner of police. Says Commissioner Srivastava: "I have named my dog Damru as he is a real delight to have around."

Sharma says Prime Minister Narendra Modi's asking people to take care of indies has also had an impact and wishes the PM adopts one as also the Rashtrapati Bhawan. But his own agenda is to set up a crematorium for dogs and an adoption centre for pets next. ■

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